But when Cripps came home admitting defeat, there seemed little more that Attlee could do. So, as Mountbatten's friend Noël Coward put it, "The position having become impossible, they call on Dickie!" Mountbatten took up the last viceroy's job as light-heartedly as he did most things, with royal panache, informing "Cousin Bertie," King George, that he viewed the idea of breaking India's political deadlock as challenging as a game of polo: "The last Chukka in India—12 goals down."[4] He got so bored, however, trying to bring Nehru, Gandhi, and Jinnah to agree upon a single plan that he swiftly opted for partition as the simplest solution.

Cyril Radcliffe was invited to India to chair the Punjab and Bengal Partition Commissions, each with two constantly divided Congress and League lawyers on it, leaving Radcliffe himself to finish drawing the two new dominions' boundary lines on the sorely inadequate maps he'd been given. The commissions had been appointed merely to divide both provinces along "Muslim versus non-Muslim majority Districts," yet Radcliffe's Punjab line cut through the heart of Punjab's central canal colony land, where some six million Sikhs lived, since Mountbatten refused to consider Sikh demands for a state of their own. Nor could Radcliffe resist pressure from Mountbatten, who had accepted Nehru's flattering invitation to serve as independent India's first governor-general, and so acceded to Nehru's passionate insistence that the Gurdaspur District of Punjab be awarded to India, despite its Muslim majority, since without it, India would have been deprived of direct road access to the Vale of Kashmir. Nehru also demanded that the Muslim-majority subdistrict of Ferozepur, with its mighty hydroelectric generators, be included in India's Punjab for vital strategic reasons. Mountbatten, judging the strategic risk of losing Ferozepur too high a price for India to pay, persuaded Radcliffe to redraw his initial Punjab line accordingly, though neither he nor Mountbatten ever admitted the latter's "pressure."[5]

Anguished Hindu-Sikh refugee columns grew into human flood lines as they left the burning city of Lahore, trudging twenty miles east to the border town at Wagah, and another twenty miles beyond that to Indian Punjab's new capital, Amritsar, sacred to all Sikhs. The founder of Sikhism, Guru Nanak, was born in West Punjab's Sheikhupura District; his Gurdwara temple, marking that sacred birthplace, Nankana Sahib, was left to Pakistan and remained a place of pilgrimage for Indian Sikhs. The saintly Guru Nanak won converts wherever he went, and his gentle